

Chapter 9 — New Empires and Kingdoms

The Guptas, Harshavardhana, and the Rise of the South

The one-line point: After the Mauryas, India fragments — then the **Guptas** rebuild an empire and preside over what's often called a "Golden Age." Then it fragments again, and this time **South India** — Pallavas, Chalukyas, Cholas — becomes the centre of gravity.

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Ancient India
Sub-discipline	Classical / Imperial Period (Gupta age) + Early Medieval transition (South Indian kingdoms)
Period	~319 CE – 750 CE
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → Gupta rulers, prashastis, administration, land grants, South Indian dynasties
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ <i>Indian culture</i> : Gupta and Chola contributions to art, literature and architecture — asked verbatim in 2022
Also feeds	Art & Culture ★ ★ ★ (temple architecture begins here — Nagara/Dravida; Ajanta; sculpture), Polity ★ ★ (Chola/Pallava village assemblies — <i>ur, sabha, nagaram</i> , and the Uttaramerur inscription — a top-tier "roots of Indian democracy" citation), Economy (land grants, feudalism debate), Science (Aryabhata)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ ★ — high, and rising because of the Art & Culture linkage
Overlaps with	Ch.10 (which is the art/literature/science of exactly this period), Ch.8 (Xuan Zang)

 **Ancient India → Classical.** For Mains, this is where **temple architecture** and the **Chola local self-government** material lives. **The Uttaramerur inscription alone justifies studying this chapter carefully.**

Learning Outcomes

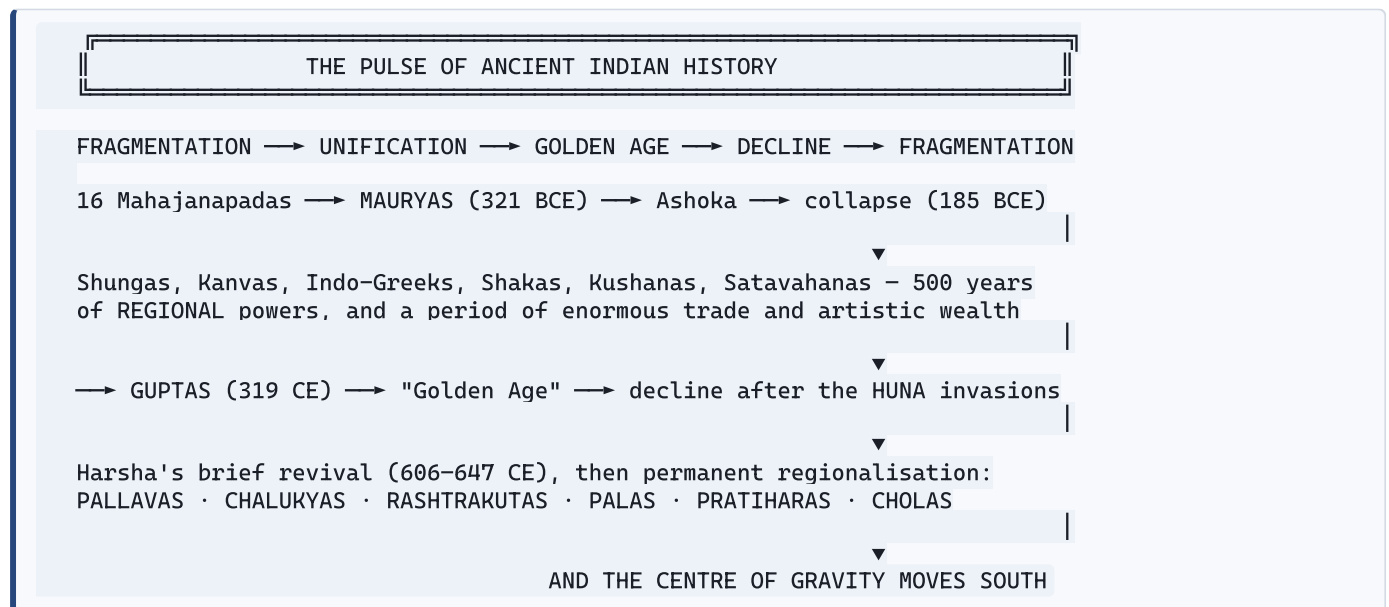
By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Define** a *prashasti* and explain its value **and** its bias as a historical source.
- ☐ **Sequence** the Gupta rulers and state each one's contribution.
- ☐ **Summarise** the **Prayag/Allahabad Prashasti** — author, four categories of conquered rulers, and its physical location oddity.
- ☐ **Describe** Gupta administration and explain the **land-grant system** and the "Indian feudalism" debate.
- ☐ **Assess** the "Golden Age" label critically — the case for and against.
- ☐ **Describe Harshavardhana** — sources, extent, defeat, and administration.

- ☐ **Name** the major South Indian dynasties, their capitals and their achievements.
- ☐ **Explain** the **Pallava–Chalukya conflict** and the **Aihole inscription**.
- ☐ **Describe** the Chola/Pallava local assemblies — *ur**, *sabha*, **nagaram* — and the **Uttaramerur** election procedure in detail.
- ☐ **Explain** what a *samanta* was and how the political structure was changing.
- ☐ **State** the significance of **712 CE**.
- ☐ **Describe** ordinary people's lives as reported by **Xuan Zang** and the *Harshacharita*.

Start Here: The Rhythm of Indian History

Notice a pattern that has now happened twice, and will happen again:



 **The insight worth carrying:** "fragmentation" is not the same as "decline." The **post-Mauryan** centuries of political fragmentation produced the **greatest trade boom** and the **first Buddha images** (Ch.8). The **post-Gupta** fragmentation produced the **greatest temples** (Ch.10). **Political unity and cultural achievement are not the same variable** — and saying so is a genuinely sophisticated point in a Mains answer.

The Software Engineer's Analogy

Watch the **architecture** of the Indian state change across these chapters:

MAURYAN MODEL (Ch.7)

→ GUPTA / POST-GUPTA MODEL

Salaried officials appointed and paid by the centre; recallable, rotatable

→ LAND GRANTS: officials and brahmanas given LAND and the RIGHT TO COLLECT ITS REVENUE, often tax-free and HEREDITARY

Centre holds revenue and disburses salaries

→ Revenue collection is DELEGATED permanently and irrevocably

Direct central control

→ SAMANTAS – subordinate rulers who keep their own territory, army and revenue, and owe the overlord tribute, troops and attendance

THE TRADE-OFF:

Cheap and scalable – you don't need a huge paid bureaucracy or a fast communication network. BUT you have permanently GIVEN AWAY the revenue stream and the coercive capacity. Each grantee becomes an independent power centre. Over generations, the centre progressively LOSES CONTROL of resources it can never reclaim.

 **This is the heart of the "Indian feudalism" debate** (associated especially with **R. S. Sharma**), and it's a real Mains topic. The Mauryan model was **centralised and expensive**; the Gupta and post-Gupta model was **decentralised and cheap** — and the price was long-run fragmentation. **Framing it as a deliberate trade-off rather than mere "decline" produces a much better answer.**

1 PRASHASTIS — A New Kind of Source

A **PRASHASTI** (Sanskrit: "in praise of") is an **inscription composed by a court poet in praise of a king**.

Aspect	Detail
Language	★ SANSKRIT — note the change. Ashoka used Prakrit (Ch.7); the Guptas use Sanskrit . Sanskrit is now the language of power and prestige
Content	The king's lineage, conquests, virtues, learning, generosity, physical beauty — often in elaborate poetry
Value	Gives us names, campaigns, geography, dynastic sequence, and court culture
 Bias ★★	They are eulogies. They exaggerate, omit defeats, and describe an ideal rather than a record. Never treat a prashasti as neutral reportage

 **A prashasti is a marketing page authored by the vendor.** The product names and version numbers are usually accurate — the performance claims are not. **Use it for facts; discount its evaluations.** Saying exactly this in a Mains answer is worth marks.

★★★ **The Prayag Prashasti (Allahabad Pillar Inscription)**
The single most important inscription of the Gupta period.

Element	Detail
About	SAMUDRAGUPTA
Composed by	HARISHENA — his court poet and minister ★
Language	Sanskrit , in a mix of verse and prose (<i>champu</i> style)
Where	On a pillar at Allahabad (Prayagraj)
★ The delicious oddity	It is inscribed on an ASHOKAN PILLAR. Samudragupta's eulogy was carved onto a pillar already bearing Ashoka's edicts , ~600 years older. The same stone carries the message of a king who renounced conquest and, beneath it, the boasts of a king who conquered relentlessly. ★ (<i>The pillar was later moved to Allahabad Fort by Akbar, and Jahangir added an inscription too — three empires on one stone.</i>)

The four categories of rulers Samudragupta dealt with — learn this classification, it's asked:

Category	Who	How they were treated
1. Aryavarta (north India) — 9 rulers	Rulers of the Ganga valley	★ UPROOTED and their territory ANNEXED — total conquest
2. Dakshinapatha (south) — 12 rulers	Rulers of the Deccan and further south	★ DEFEATED, then REINSTATED as tributaries — the <i>dharmavijaya</i> model. He could not hold the south, so he extracted submission and went home
3. Forest/Atavika rulers	Central Indian forest chiefs	Reduced to servitude
4. Frontier states and ganas	Border kingdoms (Samatata, Davaka, Kamarupa, Nepala, Kartipura) and republics (Malavas, Yaudheyas, Arjunayanas, Madrakas, Abhiras)	Submitted, paid tribute, obeyed orders — not annexed. ★ Note that ganas still existed here (Ch.5 link) and were finally absorbed in this period
5. Foreign rulers	Kushanas, Shakas, the king of Sri Lanka (Meghavarna)	Sought his favour, offered daughters in marriage, sent gifts

🎯 **The north/south distinction is the analytically interesting bit.** Samudragupta **annexed** the north and merely **subdued** the south. That tells you where the Gupta empire's real, administered territory ended — a distinction that a careless "he conquered all India" answer misses entirely.

Harishena also praises Samudragupta as: a poet (*kaviraja*), a **musician** (some of his gold coins show him playing the **VEENA** ★), a patron of learning, and one who performed the **Ashvamedha** (his *ashvamedha*-type coins survive).

2 🏆 THE GUPTA DYNASTY (c. 319–550 CE)

THE GUPTA RULERS

SRI GUPTA → GHATOTKACHA

| (the earliest known, called "maharaja" – modest titles)

CHANDRAGUPTA I (c. 319–335 CE)

- Took the grand title MAHARAJADHIRAJA ("great king of kings")
- Married KUMARADEVI, a LICCHAVI princess – a crucial alliance
- Coins show BOTH of them, and name the Licchavis
- The GUPTA ERA begins in 319–320 CE

SAMUDRAGUPTA (c. 335–375 CE)

- The great conqueror. PRAYAG PRASHASTI by HARISHENA
- Called "INDIAN NAPOLEON" by V. A. Smith
- Performed the ASHVAMEDHA
- A poet and VEENA-player (shown on his coins)
- Sri Lankan king Meghavarna sought permission to build a monastery at Bodh Gaya

CHANDRAGUPTA II "VIKRAMADITYA" (c. 375–415 CE)

- DEFEATED THE SHAKAS of western India → gained Gujarat and Malwa → gained access to the WESTERN SEA PORTS → trade boom → hence the title SHAKARI ("enemy of the Shakas")
- FA XIAN visited India during his reign (399–414 CE)
- Traditionally associated with the NAVARATNAS ("nine gems"), including KALIDASA and (traditionally) VARAHAMIHIRA – though the Navaratna list is a LATER tradition, treat with care
- Issued the first Gupta SILVER coins (for the western regions)
- The MEHRAULI IRON PILLAR is attributed to a king "CHANDRA"

KUMARAGUPTA I (c. 415–455 CE)

- Traditionally credited with FOUNDING NALANDA MAHA VIHARA
- Faced the first Huna pressure

SKANDAGUPTA (c. 455–467 CE)

- REPELLED THE HUNAS (Hephthalites/White Huns) – the last great Gupta military achievement
- REPAIRED THE SUDARSHANA LAKE at Girnar – recorded in the JUNAGADH inscription (on the same rock as Ashoka's edicts and Rudradaman's inscription!)
- The wars drained the treasury; gold content of coins declines

Weak successors · renewed HUNA invasions (Toramana, Mihirakula) · rise of feudatories → THE EMPIRE FADES BY ~550 CE

Gupta administration

Feature	Detail
Nature	⚠️ LESS centralised than the Mauryas. The Guptas ruled the core directly and governed the periphery through subordinate/tributary rulers
Titles	<i>Maharajadhiraja, Parama-bhattaraka, Parameshvara</i> — grand titles reflecting a claim to paramountcy
Divisions	<i>Bhukti</i> (province, under an <i>uparika</i>) → <i>Vishaya</i> (district, under a <i>vishayapati</i>) → <i>Grama</i> (village)
Key innovation: LAND GRANTS ★★	Land given to brahmanas (<i>agrahara/brahmadeya</i>) and to officials, recorded on COPPER PLATES , frequently tax-free and hereditary , and often carrying the right to collect revenue and even administer
Officials often unpaid in cash	Paid instead by assignment of land revenue → hereditary offices emerge
Army	Feudatory levies significant alongside the standing army
Coins ★	Magnificent GOLD coins (<i>dinaras</i>) — the most beautiful in ancient India: king with bow, axe, lyre/veena, tiger-slaying, ashvamedha, king-and-queen types

★ **Why land grants matter so much** (this is the analytical core of the chapter): giving land **permanently and tax-free** to a grantee means the state has **irrevocably surrendered that revenue** and, increasingly, the administrative and judicial authority over that area. Over generations the grantees become **local lords**, and the centre becomes a coordinator of semi-independent powers. **This is the process historians debate as "Indian feudalism."**

 It's delegating an entitlement permanently instead of leasing it — you get immediate loyalty and zero administrative overhead, but you have given away the capability with no revocation mechanism. **Repeat that a few hundred times over two centuries and the centre is hollow.**

Was it a "Golden Age"? — Argue Both Sides

This is a standard Mains question. A one-sided answer is a weak answer.

✓ The case FOR	✗ The case AGAINST
Literature: Kalidasa, the Puranas compiled, Sanskrit drama flourishes	Rigid caste: varna hierarchy hardened; untouchability intensified — Fa Xian records that <i>chandals</i> had to strike a warning stick on entering a town ★
Science: Aryabhata , Varahamihira, Brahmagupta; decimal system and zero	Women's position declined — earlier marriage, restricted property rights, and the first epigraphic record of sati (Eran inscription, 510 CE) ★
Art: Ajanta paintings, exquisite sculpture, temple architecture begins	Slavery and forced labour (<i>vishti</i>) continued and arguably grew
Gold coinage of high purity and artistry	Prosperity was uneven — concentrated in the north and among elites; the "golden age" was golden for a narrow stratum
Political stability across much of north India	Not pan-Indian — the south was outside it; and the label was coined by nationalist historiography partly to counter colonial claims of Indian backwardness
Trade and urban life substantial	Urban decline may have begun late in the period; land grants signal ruralisation

 **The formulation that scores:** *"The Gupta period saw exceptional achievement in literature, science and art, but the 'Golden Age' label — a product of nationalist historiography — obscures intensifying caste rigidity, a decline in women's status, and the uneven distribution of prosperity. It was a golden age for a narrow elite, not for society as a whole."*

The Hunas

Huna (Hephthalite/White Hun) invasions from Central Asia hit the Guptas from the mid-5th century. **Skandagupta repelled them**, but the wars **drained the treasury** (visible in the declining gold content of coins). Later **Toramana** and **Mihirakula** established Huna rule in north-west India before being defeated by a coalition including **Yashodharman** of Malwa. **The Hunas were a major contributory cause of Gupta decline.**

3 🏰 HARSHAVARDHANA (r. 606–647 CE)

The last great ruler of northern India before the medieval period.

Aspect	Detail
Dynasty	Pushyabhuti (Vardhana) dynasty
Original capital	Thanesar (Sthanvishvara), Haryana → shifted to 🌟 KANAUJ (Kanyakubja)
How he came to power 🌟	His elder brother Rajyavardhana was killed by Shashanka of Gauda (Bengal). Harsha, only ~16, succeeded and also took over Kanauj on behalf of his widowed sister RAJYASHRI — whom he rescued from the Vindhya forest as she was about to immolate herself
Extent	Most of north India — Punjab, UP, Bihar, Bengal, Odisha; and Gujarat/Malwa influence
🌟 THE GREAT CHECK	DEFEATED by PULAKESHIN II of the Chalukyas on the banks of the NARMADA (c. 618–619 CE). Harsha could never expand south of the Narmada — the river became the boundary between them 🌟🌟
Religion	Raised a Shaiva; became a patron of Buddhism (Mahayana) , but remained tolerant — patronised Shaivism and the Sun as well
Assemblies 🌟	Held a grand assembly at KANAUJ in honour of Xuan Zang, and a quinquennial (every 5 years) distribution of charity at PRAYAG (Allahabad) , giving away his accumulated wealth
Administration	Similar to the Guptas but more decentralised ; heavy reliance on feudatories (samantas) ; more land grants , now also to officials
Death	Died 647 CE without an heir → the empire dissolved immediately. His minister Arunashva usurped power and attacked a Chinese mission, prompting a Tibetan–Nepali force to intervene

The sources for Harsha 🌟🌟 — a great Chapter 1 case study

Source	Author	Note
HARSHACHARITA 🌟🌟	BANABHATTA — his court poet	A Sanskrit biography; the first historical biography (charita) in Sanskrit literature 🌟. Eulogistic and incomplete (it breaks off early), but rich on court life
SI-YU-KI 🌟🌟	XUAN ZANG	The Chinese pilgrim's account — outsider's perspective; describes administration, Nalanda, cities, roads and society
Harsha's own plays 🌟	Harsha himself	Nagananda, Ratnavali, Priyadarshika — he was a genuine dramatist
Inscriptions	—	Banskhera and Madhuban copper plates (which bear Harsha's own signature 🌟)

🎯 This is the ideal source situation and worth pointing out in an answer: you have a **court biography** (insider, flattering), a **foreign traveller's account** (outsider, differently biased), the ruler's **own literary works**, and **inscriptions** (contemporary, official). **Triangulating across all four is exactly the method Chapter 1 taught.**

Xuan Zang on Harsha's India: roads reasonably safe but robbery not unknown (he was himself robbed); punishments harsher than under the Guptas; **taxation light** — **about 1/6**; a well-organised charity system;

Nalanda thriving with thousands of students.

4 🌴 THE SOUTH RISES

The most important structural development of this chapter: **after the Guptas, the political and cultural centre of gravity shifts south.**

Dynasty	Capital	Period	Known for
PALLAVAS ★★	KANCHIPURAM	~3rd–9th c. CE	★ Mahabalipuram (rathas, Shore Temple), Kailasanatha temple at Kanchi; rock-cut → structural temple transition ; Mahendravarman I (also a playwright — <i>Mattavilasa Prahasana</i>), Narasimhavarman I "Mamalla" (defeated and sacked Vatapi)
CHALUKYAS of Badami ★★	BADAMI (Vatapi)	~6th–8th c. CE	★ AIHOLE, BADAMI, PATTADAKAL temples (Pattadakal is a UNESCO World Heritage Site); PULAKESHIN II — defeated Harsha
PANDYAS	Madurai	Revived ~6th c.	South Tamil Nadu; Meenakshi temple tradition
CHOLAS ★★★	Thanjavur (later Gangaikondacholapuram)	Great from ~9th c.	★ Village self-government ; Brihadeshwara temple ; bronze Nataraja ; naval power
RASHTRAKUTAS ★	Manyakheta	8th–10th c.	★ KAILASHNATHA TEMPLE at ELLORA (Krishna I) — the world's largest monolithic rock-cut structure
PALAS	Bengal/Bihar	8th–12th c.	Buddhism; Vikramshila and Odantapuri universities; Dharmapala, Devapala
PRATI HARAS	Kanauj	8th–11th c.	One of the three contenders in the Tripartite Struggle

★ **The Tripartite Struggle — Palas (east), Pratiharas (west/north), Rashtrakutas (Deccan)** fought for control of **KANAUJ** for roughly two centuries (8th–10th c.). Kanauj had become the symbolic key to north Indian paramountcy after Harsha. **Know the three names and the prize.**

⚔️ **Pallava vs Chalukya — and the Aihole Inscription** ★★

The two great southern powers fought repeatedly across the Tungabhadra doab.

- **PULAKESHIN II** (Chalukya, r. 610–642) — his achievements are recorded in the ★★ **AIHOLE INSCRIPTION**, composed by his court poet **RAVIKIRTI** in **Sanskrit**. It records his **victory over Harshavardhana** and is one of the most important inscriptions of South India. (*Ravikirti immodestly compares himself to Kalidasa and Bharavi in the same inscription.*)
- Pulakeshin II also received an **embassy from the Persian king Khusrav II** — depicted, it is thought, in an **Ajanta painting** ★
- **NARASIMHAVARMAN I "MAMALLA"** (Pallava) avenged earlier defeats by **capturing and sacking the Chalukya capital VATAPI (Badami)** in c. 642, taking the title **Vatapikonda** ("conqueror of Vatapi"), and **Pulakeshin II died** in that conflict
- **Mahabalipuram (Mamallapuram)** is named after **Mamalla** ★

🔴 **Compressed: "Pulakeshin II beat Harsha at the Narmada; Narasimhavarman I sacked Pulakeshin's capital Vatapi."** Both facts are asked.

📌 ★★★ SOUTH INDIAN LOCAL SELF-GOVERNMENT — The Crown Jewel

This is the single most valuable thing in this chapter for cross-syllabus use.

Village assemblies in Pallava and especially **Chola** territory:

Assembly	Composition
UR ★	Assembly of a general/ordinary village — of the landholding cultivators (non-brahmadeya villages)
SABHA ★★	Assembly of a BRAHMADEYA village — one granted to brahmanas . The most elaborately organised
NAGARAM ★	Assembly of merchants — governing a trading town

The **sabha** worked through committees (**variyams**) — for irrigation (*eri-variya*m), gardens, justice, temples, gold, and annual affairs.

🏛️ The Uttaramerur Inscription ★★★

Learn this. It is repeatedly asked and is superb Mains material.

At **Uttaramerur** (**Kanchipuram district, Tamil Nadu**), inscriptions of the Chola king **PARANTAKA I** (c. **921 CE**) record, in extraordinary procedural detail, how the village assembly's committee members were selected.

THE UTTARAMERUR ELECTION PROCEDURE (KUDAVOLAI SYSTEM)

QUALIFICATIONS TO STAND:

- Own tax-paying land of a prescribed minimum extent
- Own a house on legally-owned land
- Be between 35 and 70 years of age
- Know the Vedas and administration (or, with less land, be well-versed in one Veda and its commentaries)
- Be honest and have earned income by honest means

DISQUALIFICATIONS – genuinely remarkable:

- Anyone who has served on a committee in the last 3 years
→ A COOLING-OFF / ROTATION RULE
- Anyone who has NOT SUBMITTED ACCOUNTS of a previous term
→ AUDIT AND ACCOUNTABILITY, enforced by disqualification
- Anyone (or their relatives) guilty of specified offences, theft, or having taken others' property
- Those who had committed sins, or associated with outcastes

THE METHOD – "KUDAVOLAI" ("pot-ticket"):

1. Names of eligible candidates from each ward written on palm-leaf tickets
2. Tickets placed in a POT
3. A YOUNG BOY, too young to have any interest, draws the tickets out in a public assembly
4. The drawn names are read out and appointed to committees
→ SELECTION BY LOT from a QUALIFIED, VETTED pool

🔗 **Why this earns marks in almost any governance answer:** here, in a 10th-century village inscription, are **eligibility criteria, explicit disqualifications, an anti-incumbency/rotation rule, a mandatory audit requirement enforced by debarment, and a transparent public selection procedure.** Those are the components of modern electoral law.

⚠️ **But be honest about the limits, exactly as with the gana-sanghas (Ch.5):** participation was restricted to **male, property-owning, Veda-learned brahmanas** in the *brahmadeya* villages. **It was sophisticated local self-government, not universal franchise.**

🔗 **The full lineage to deploy in GS2: Vajji gana-sangha (Ch.5) → Buddhist sangha's procedural rules (Ch.6) → Chola *sabha* and Uttaramerur (Ch.9) → 73rd/74th Amendments. That four-point arc is one of the strongest introductions you can write for a question on local self-government or the roots of Indian democracy.** Cross-reference your Polity notes.

5 ⚙️ How Kingdoms Were Changing: Samantas and Land Grants

Term	Meaning
SAMANTA ★★	A subordinate ruler . He kept his own territory, army and revenue; in return he brought gifts, troops when summoned, and attended the overlord's court . If the overlord weakened, the samanta declared independence
Brahmadeya* / *Agrahara ★	Land granted to brahmanas , usually tax-free and hereditary
Devadana	Land granted to a temple
Copper plates ★	The medium on which grants were recorded — the legal title deed

🔗 **Why kings made these grants** — give more than one reason in an answer:

1. **Religious merit** and legitimacy
2. **To extend agriculture into forest and tribal areas** — brahmana settlers brought plough agriculture, new crops, and a new social order to frontier regions ★ (a genuinely important, often-missed function)
3. **To reward officials without cash** in an economy where coinage was contracting
4. **To spread Sanskrit culture and legitimising ideology** into newly-incorporated regions

⚠️ **The long-run cost:** each grant permanently alienated revenue and authority. **Kings were buying short-term loyalty with long-term sovereignty.**

6 📅 712 CE — A Date to Note

In **712 CE**, an Arab army under **MUHAMMAD BIN QASIM** conquered **SINDH**, defeating **Raja Dahir**.

- The first significant **Arab/Islamic political presence** in the subcontinent
- Its **direct political impact was limited and regional** — Sindh remained a frontier province and Arab power did not penetrate further
- But it opened sustained contact: ★ **Indian mathematics and astronomy (including the decimal numeral system and Brahmagupta's works) passed to the Arab world through this contact**, and thence to Europe as "Arabic numerals"

 **The intellectually satisfying part:** the numeral system you use daily travelled **India** → **Arab world** → **Europe**, which is why Europeans call them "Arabic numerals" while Arabs called them *al-arqam al-hindiyyah* — "Indian numerals." **Ch.10 will give you Aryabhata and Brahmagupta, the source of that export.**

7 Ordinary People's Lives

NCERT deliberately closes with the non-royal.

From the *Harshacharita*, Xuan Zang, and Sanskrit drama:

- **Villages were the overwhelming reality** — most people were cultivators, herders, artisans and labourers
-  **A striking observation from Sanskrit plays:** the **kings and brahmanas speak SANSKRIT**, while **women and lower-status characters speak PRAKRIT**. **The language on stage encodes the social hierarchy** — a beautiful, quotable illustration of how deeply stratification ran
- **Xuan Zang** describes **untouchability** clearly — *chandalas* lived outside towns and had to announce their approach
- **Land grants brought new pressures** — villagers now owed dues to a grantee rather than the state, and their obligations were fixed in a copper plate they could not read
- **Slavery and *vishti* (forced labour)** continued

 **The Sanskrit/Prakrit split in drama is worth pausing on.** It's an access-control model expressed through language: the prestige register is available only to those with the social permissions to use it, and the play *encodes and reinforces* those permissions every time it's performed. **Chapter 6's insight — that the Buddha's choice of Prakrit was itself radical — lands with full force here.**

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Prashasti ★★	Eulogistic inscription; Sanskrit (contrast: Ashoka's Prakrit)
Prayag Prashasti ★★ ★	Samudragupta , by Harishena , on an Ashokan pillar at Allahabad
Four categories ★	Aryavarta uprooted/annexed ; Dakshinapatha defeated then reinstated
Chandragupta I ★	Maharajadhiraja ; Licchavi marriage (Kumaradevi); Gupta era 319–320 CE
Samudragupta ★★	"Indian Napoleon"; veena coins; Ashvamedha
Chandragupta II ★★ ★	Defeated the Shakas → western ports; Fa Xian visited; Vikramaditya; Navaratnas (later tradition)
Kumaragupta I ★	Founded Nalanda
Skandagupta ★★	Repelled the Hunas ; repaired the Sudarshana lake (Junagadh inscription)
Gupta coins	Superb gold dinaras ; Chandragupta II issued the first silver
Land grants ★★	Recorded on copper plates ; often tax-free and hereditary; the "Indian feudalism" debate
Harsha ★★	606–647 CE ; Thanesar → Kanauj ; sister Rajyashri ; defeated by Pulakeshin II on the Narmada
Harsha's sources ★★ ★	Harshacharita by Banabhatta ; Xuan Zang ; his own plays Nagananda , Ratnavali , Priyadarshika
Pulakeshin II ★★	Chalukya of Badami/Vatapi ; Aihole inscription by Ravikirti
Narasimhavarman I ★	Pallava; sacked Vatapi ; Mamallapuram named after him
Pallava capital ★	Kanchipuram
Local assemblies ★★ ★	ur (general village), sabha (brahmadeya), nagaram (merchants)
Uttaramerur ★★ ★	Parantaka I Chola ; kudavolai (pot-ticket) system; age 35–70; land and Vedic knowledge required; 3-year cooling-off ; accounts must be submitted
Samanta ★	Subordinate ruler with own army and revenue
Tripartite Struggle ★	Palas , Pratiharas , Rashtrakutas over Kanauj
712 CE ★	Muhammad bin Qasim conquers Sindh (defeats Raja Dahir)
Hunas ★	Repelled by Skandagupta; later Toramana and Mihirakula

Traps:

- "The Gupta empire was more centralised than the Mauryan" → **FALSE**. Less centralised
- "Ashokan and Gupta inscriptions are both in Prakrit" → **FALSE**. Ashoka = **Prakrit**; Gupta prashastis = **Sanskrit**
- "Harsha defeated Pulakeshin II" → **FALSE**. The reverse — Harsha was defeated at the Narmada
- "Xuan Zang visited Chandragupta II" → **FALSE**. That was **Fa Xian**; Xuan Zang came under **Harsha**
- "Samudragupta annexed South India" → **FALSE**. He defeated and **reinstated** southern rulers
- "The **ur** was the assembly of a brahmadeya village" → **FALSE**. That's the **sabha**
- "Uttaramerur shows universal adult franchise" → **FALSE**. Restricted to qualified, property-owning, Veda-learned men

Mains

- **Art & Culture** ★ ★ ★: "Discuss the main contributions of the Gupta period and the Chola period to Indian heritage and culture." (UPSC 2022) — this exact question has been asked
- **Polity/Governance** ★ ★ ★: the **Uttaramerur inscription** and Chola local self-government as the historical lineage of Panchayati Raj
- **The "Golden Age" debate** ★ ★: argue both sides; note the nationalist-historiography origin of the label
- **Economy/Society** ★: land grants, samantas, and the "Indian feudalism" debate (R. S. Sharma)
- **Source criticism**: Harsha's reign as a model case of triangulating four source types

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Prashasti	Eulogistic inscription praising a ruler
Maharajadhiraja	"Great king of kings"
Bhukti / Vishaya / Grama	Province / district / village
Uparika / Vishayapati	Provincial / district governor
Samanta	Subordinate ruler owing tribute and troops
Brahmadeya / Agrahara	Land granted to brahmanas
Devadana	Land granted to a temple
Dinara	Gupta gold coin
Ur	Assembly of an ordinary village
Sabha	Assembly of a brahmadeya village
Nagaram	Assembly of merchants
Variyam	Committee of the sabha
Kudavolai	The Chola "pot-ticket" selection method
Ashvamedha	Horse sacrifice (revived by Samudragupta)
Huna	Hephthalite/White Hun invaders
Harshacharita	Banabhatta's biography of Harsha
Si-Yu-Ki	Xuan Zang's account of India
Charita	Biography (a Sanskrit genre)

2-MINUTE RECAP

1. **Prashastis** are Sanskrit eulogies — factually useful, evaluatively biased. Note the language shift: **Ashoka = Prakrit; Guptas = Sanskrit**.
2. **Prayag Prashasti: Samudragupta**, composed by **Harishena**, carved on an **Ashokan pillar**. North rulers **uprooted**; southern rulers **defeated and reinstated**.
3. **Gupta rulers**: Chandragupta I (**Licchavi marriage**, Gupta era 319 CE) → **Samudragupta** (conqueror, veena) → **Chandragupta II (beat the Shakas, Fa Xian, Vikramaditya)** → Kumaragupta I (**Nalanda**) → **Skandagupta (repelled the Hunas, Sudarshana lake)**.

4. **Gupta administration was LESS centralised than Mauryan**, relying on **land grants on copper plates** — often tax-free and hereditary → the "**Indian feudalism**" debate.
 5. "**Golden Age**" is **contested**: brilliant literature, science and art, but hardening caste, declining women's status (**first sati record, Eran 510 CE**), and uneven prosperity.
 6. **Harsha (606–647)**: Thanesar → **Kanauj**; sister **Rajyashri**; **defeated by Pulakeshin II at the Narmada**; sources = *Harshacharita* (Banabhatta), **Xuan Zang**, his own **three plays**, and inscriptions.
 7. **The south rises: Pallavas** (Kanchipuram, Mahabalipuram), **Chalukyas** (Badami; Aihole, Pattadakal), **Cholas** (Thanjavur), **Rashtrakutas** (Ellora Kailashnatha), **Palas, Pratiharas**.
 8. **Pulakeshin II (Aihole inscription by Ravikirti)** beat Harsha; **Narasimhavarman I** later sacked **Vatapi**.
 9. **Tripartite Struggle**: Palas, Pratiharas, Rashtrakutas fight over **Kanauj**.
 10. **Local self-government**: **ur** (ordinary village), **sabha** (brahmadeya, with **variyaams**), **nagaram** (merchants).
 11. **Uttaramerur (Parantaka I, c. 921 CE)**: the **kudavolai** pot-ticket system — age 35–70, property and learning qualifications, **3-year cooling-off**, **mandatory submission of accounts**. Sophisticated but **restricted** franchise.
 12. **Samantas** kept their own armies and revenue — the political structure was devolving.
 13. **712 CE: Muhammad bin Qasim** takes **Sindh**; the contact route by which **Indian numerals reached the Arab world and then Europe**.
 14. **In Sanskrit drama, kings and brahmanas speak Sanskrit while women and lower-status characters speak Prakrit** — hierarchy encoded in language itself.
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Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. The Prayag Prashasti of Samudragupta —
 1. was composed by Harishena.
 2. is inscribed on a pillar that also bears Ashokan edicts.
 3. records that southern rulers were defeated and then reinstated. → *All three*.
2. Consider the following statements about the Uttaramerur inscriptions:
 1. They describe the selection of village committee members by lot.
 2. Anyone who had not submitted accounts of a previous term was disqualified.
 3. They date to the reign of Rajaraja Chola. → *1 and 2 only. They belong to Parantaka I.*
3. Which pair is correctly matched?
 1. *Harshacharita* — Banabhatta
 2. Aihole inscription — Ravikirti
 3. Prayag Prashasti — Kalidasa → *1 and 2 only. The Prayag Prashasti is by Harishena.*
4. Harshavardhana's southward expansion was checked by — → *Pulakeshin II of the Chalukyas, on the Narmada.*
5. Which Gupta ruler is credited with repelling the Huna invasions? → *Skandagupta.*
6. In the Chola period, the assembly of a *brahmadeya* village was called the — → *Sabha. (Ur = ordinary village; nagaram = merchants.)*

Mains style

7. Discuss the main contributions of the Gupta period and the Chola period to Indian heritage and culture. **(250 words) — UPSC 2022**
8. *"The Gupta period was a golden age only for a narrow elite."* Critically examine. **(250 words)**
9. *"The Chola system of local self-government anticipated several principles of modern representative government, but not its inclusiveness."* Discuss. **(250 words)**
10. Examine the significance of land grants in transforming the political structure of early medieval India. **(250 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- What is a prashasti, and what are its two limitations as a source?
- Why is the Prayag Prashasti's *location* historically ironic?
- How did Samudragupta treat northern rulers differently from southern ones, and why?
- Give three arguments for and three against the "Golden Age" label.
- Name four sources for Harsha's reign and one bias of each.
- Describe the kudavolai system in five steps.
- What is a *samanta*, and why did the samanta system weaken kings over time?